Mission Gold

RAVI DAHIYA, 24

Wrestler, Sonepat, Haryana

The nation cheered as Ravi Kumar Dahiya stood on the podium to accept the silver medal in the men's freestyle 57kg clash at the Tokyo Games, but the smile was missing from the grappler's face. Dahiya was very disappointed by his close loss in the finals to Russia's Zaur Ugeyev and later apologised to his fans.

Son of a small farmer from Haryana, Dahiya's journey in wrestling has been an uphill climb. In 2003, he moved to Delhi's Chhatrasal Stadium—the Mecca of wrestlers in India—and spent years practising. His father, Rakesh Dahiya, would travel 40 km every day from his village in Sonepat to get him milk, fruits and vegetables.

An Olympic silver is no mean feat, and Dahiya, to his credit, had made history by becoming only the second Indian wrestler—after Sushil Kumar—to bag an individual silver medal at the Games. Kumar's silver had come at the 2012 Olympics in London. Not the one to rest on his laurels, Dahiya returned from Tokyo and immediately got down to preparing for the 2024 Paris Games. Coach Ramphal Mann says Dahiya's only dream is to win an Olympic gold for the country and that he is working hard to realise it. ■

–Anilesh S. Mahajan

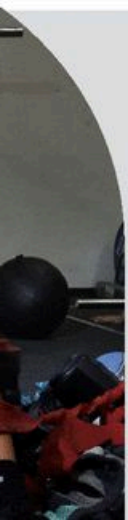
RACE AGAINST TIME
Dahiya practises for more than 18 hours a day, putting his time on the mat before all work and promotional activity

"Ravi is very focused and training hard for Paris. He doesn't allow himself any distraction from the aim of winning an Olympic gold"

RAMPHAL MANN
Coach



LEAH MILLIS/REUTERS



RAJ K RAJ/GETTY IMAGES)

LOVLINA BORGOHAIN, 24, *Boxer, Golaghat,* Assam

Fearless Fighter

She symbolises a fearless India. Young boxers like her will ensure many more Olympic medals in the future," Ajay Singh, president of the Boxing Federation of India, says about Lovlina Borgohain, whose bronze at the Tokyo Games in the women's 69 kg welterweight event made her only the third Indian boxer to win an Olympic medal. But it wasn't really unexpected considering Borgohain had won bronze medals at the AIBA Women's World Boxing Championships in 2018 and 2019 and at the World Championships in Russia in 2019. What makes Borgohain's Tokyo feat all the more incredible is that she had tested positive for Covid-19 just months ago, and her mother was battling a life-threatening ailment. It delayed her trip to Italy, where India's Olympic-bound boxers trained before travelling to Tokyo. Fearless is perhaps the most apt word for Borgohain—in the quarterfinals, she was up against former world champion Nien-Chin Chen, to whom she had lost four times. But then, overcoming fear and obstacles has been a part of her journey through abject poverty and adverse conditions. The bronze in Tokyo is just the beginning. Borgohain has set her sights on a gold in the next Olympics. ■

– Kaushik Deka

HOPE & DESPAIR
After watching a series on Lord Buddha in 2019, she delved into Buddhist philosophy, learning to control her emotions, be it victory or defeat. Yet she found her mother's ailment difficult to take.